

S T R O M E X

E X E C U T I V E K N O W L E D G E S Y S T E M

B O O K V



Go-to-Market

Sales · Customer Success · Partners · Ecosystem

The StromeX Editorial Bible · Edition II

AUTHORITY — OPERATIONAL

13 AUGUST 2026 · VERSION 2.0

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E X E C U T I V E S U M M A R Y

Volume V begins from a binding constraint: paid acquisition does not work in the founding market, so growth must come from mechanisms whose cost does not scale with customers acquired. It identifies seven such engines, of which the most defensible is that every credential a StromeX institution issues is a permanent, cost-free advertisement seen by an employer or a university. It sets out the funnel, the sales motions, the sales playbook and its seven discovery questions, the discipline of public procurement, and — at its centre — the eleven-stage Customer Success Playbook with its health scoring and value ledger. It confronts the segment’s unforgiving retention benchmarks directly, sets the partner network economics deliberately above the industry norm, and defines the platform ecosystem and community programmes.

One book of ten. The corpus index and the other nine are at [docs/library/](#).

The StromeX Editorial Bible, Edition II.
Version 2.0. Published 13 August 2026.

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Composed for A4. The text is set in a serif book face with a companion sans for tabular and navigational matter, following the typographic roles defined in Volume I, Chapter 10; the StromeX brand faces Archivo and Fraunces are shipped alongside this edition and are selected by the build when they are present in the rendering environment. The press-quality PDF edition is generated from this master and the two are content-identical.

Document Control

BOOK	Book V — Go-to-Market
SERIES	The StromeX Editorial Bible — Executive Knowledge System
EDITION	Edition II
VERSION	2.0
STATUS	Ratified
CLASSIFICATION	Confidential — internal and authorised parties
AUTHORITY TIER	Operational
OWNER	Commercial Executive
REVIEW CYCLE	Annually; GTM metrics monthly
AMENDMENT PROTOCOL	Book I, Chapter 9. Four tiers: Entrenched, Constitutional, Strategic, Operational.
PRECEDENCE	Book I governs. Where this book conflicts with Book I, Book I wins until formally amended.
MASTER SOURCE	The DOCX edition of this book. The PDF is generated from it and is content-identical.
SOURCE OF RECORD	docs/bible/VOLUME-V-GTM-SALES-PARTNERS.md, under version control.
ISSUED	13 August 2026

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A live Word field. In Microsoft Word press Ctrl+A then F9 (⌘A then fn+F9 on macOS) to repaginate it, or right-click and choose Update Field; every entry is an internal hyperlink. The lists of tables and figures and the index that follow are generated by the build and already carry final page numbers.

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VOLUME

V

Go-to-Market

Sales · Customer Success · Partners · Ecosystem

AUTHORITY

Operational

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Volume V begins from a binding constraint: paid acquisition does not work in the founding market, so growth must come from mechanisms whose cost does not scale with customers acquired. It identifies seven such engines, of which the most defensible is that every credential a StromeX institution issues is a permanent, cost-free advertisement seen by an employer or a university. It sets out the funnel, the sales motions, the sales playbook and its seven discovery questions, the discipline of public procurement, and — at its centre — the eleven-stage Customer Success Playbook with its health scoring and value ledger. It confronts the segment's unforgiving retention benchmarks directly, sets the partner network economics deliberately above the industry norm, and defines the platform ecosystem and community programmes.

CHAPTER 1 — THE GO-TO-MARKET DOCTRINE

1.1 The central constraint

Paid acquisition does not work in our founding market. A Nigerian private school's lifetime value at Band A pricing does not support a Western customer-acquisition cost, and the audience is not reliably reachable through the channels that paid acquisition uses. Any GTM plan that assumes we can buy growth is arithmetically wrong.

Everything in this volume follows from that single constraint. Our growth must come from mechanisms whose cost does not scale linearly with customers acquired:

ENGINE	WHY IT SCALES SUB-LINEARLY
The free tier	One build, unlimited users, no per-acquisition cost
Referral	Proprietors know proprietors; the network does the work
The reference deployment	One visible institution recruits its peers permanently
Partners	Their relationships, not our headcount
Content & SEO	Compounds; written once, found for years
The marketplace	Third parties bring their own customers
Free verification	Every credential we issue is an advertisement seen by an employer or a university

Table 1 — The central constraint

That last one deserves emphasis. **Every certificate a StromeX institution issues is a durable marketing asset.** When an employer scans a QR code and lands on a verification page, that employer has just learned that this school is serious and that StromeX exists. It costs us nothing per scan and it reaches exactly the audience that influences other institutions. This is the cheapest and most defensible distribution mechanism the group has, and it is a direct consequence of the constitutional decision to make verification free (Volume I §5.3).

1.2 The three GTM rules

- 1. Give before asking.** Free tools, free audits, free assessments, free consultations. The Volume I §5 free constitution is a distribution strategy, not philanthropy.
- 2. Sell the next step, not the ecosystem.** A 220-student school does not need an ERP. Selling them one produces churn, a bad reference, and a lost decade of expansion revenue (Volume III §20.1 shows the correct answer).
- 3. Never sign what we cannot deliver.** Volume I §14.2. Delivery capacity is confirmed in writing before signature, by the person who will actually deliver it.

CHAPTER 2 — THE FUNNEL & THE FREE ENGINE

2.1 The funnel



Figure 1 — The funnel

Note where qualification sits: **after** free use, not before. The free tier does the qualifying, at zero cost, more honestly than a discovery call.

2.2 The free-to-paid conversion mechanics

TRIGGER	NATURAL NEXT STEP
Free timetable optimiser hits its 30-class ceiling	Paid timetable module
Free attendance register hits 200 students	Core platform, Standard
Free certificate template downloaded repeatedly	Credential platform + verification
Free SEO audit shows real problems	Technical SEO implementation
Free policy generator used for 10 policies	Policy pack or governance consultancy
Free QR generator used on printed certificates	Verified credentials — “these QR codes could actually verify”
Free readiness assessment reveals data chaos	Migration and implementation

Table 2 — The free-to-paid conversion mechanics

The rule that makes this honest: every ceiling is stated up front, on the tool, before use. A limit discovered at the moment of frustration is a trap (Volume II §4.2), and traps convert once and poison the well.

2.3 Free-tier economics governance

Foundation costs are borne centrally, never charged to divisions (Volume I §8.2), with a hard annual ceiling set by the Executive. Per-tool unit cost is monitored monthly. When the ceiling is under pressure the response order is fixed: **reduce generosity of quantity before reducing quality, and never reduce the entrenched commitments** (free verification, free export, free security, free help when we broke it).

CHAPTER 3 — THE SALES MOTIONS

MOTION	SEGMENT	CYCLE	COST TO SERVE	WHO
Self-serve	Individuals, micro-institutions, SMEs	Minutes–days	~0	Product
Low-touch	Owner-led institutions (the Phase I core)	2–8 weeks	Low	One AE, remote + occasional visit
Consultative	Committee-led institutions, groups	3–9 months	Medium	AE + solutions lead + delivery lead
Enterprise	Multi-site, corporates, large universities	6–18 months	High	Named team, executive sponsor
Procurement	Government, donor programmes	6–24 months	Very high	Bid team, compliance, references
Partner-led	Any, via a certified partner	Varies	Lowest	Partner owns it; we enable

Table 3 — The Sales Motions

The Phase I concentration rule: self-serve and low-touch only, with consultative for lighthouse accounts. Enterprise and procurement motions open in Phase II, once the reference base makes them winnable. Bidding for a ministry contract without twenty referenceable schools is a donation of proposal costs (Volume II §2.3).

CHAPTER 4 — THE SALES PLAYBOOK

4.1 Discovery — the seven questions

Before any proposal, we must be able to answer these in the customer's own words:

4. What is the institution trying to become in three years?
5. What breaks most often today, and who feels it?
6. How many hours a week does the current process consume, and whose hours?
7. What has been tried before, and why did it fail? *(This is the single most predictive question. An institution abandoned by a previous vendor buys differently and needs different reassurance.)*
8. Who decides, who influences, who can veto?
9. What does the money look like — budget cycle, approval threshold, cash rhythm?
10. What would make this a failure in their eyes, in twelve months?

A proposal written without answers to all seven is a guess, and guesses lose to competitors who asked.

4.2 The proposal standard

Every proposal contains, in this order: the institution's own stated objective in their words · what we understood · what we propose, module by module, at Volume III prices · **what is explicitly excluded** · the delivery timeline with the customer's own dependencies named and dated · what we need from them · the total, the annual, and the three-year cost · what happens if they want to leave · the named people who will do the work.

Exclusions are mandatory. Most disputes in this industry originate in something both parties assumed the other was doing.

The total does not move after signature unless the customer changes scope in writing. A vendor whose price rises after commitment has taught the customer never to trust a vendor's price again, and that damage outlives the contract.

4.3 Objection handling

Volume II §3.3 carries the five standing objections and their answers. Two additional rules:

- **"It's too expensive" is almost never about price.** It is about predictability, or about not believing the value. Respond with the value ledger and the unit economics (per student per year), not with a discount. Volume III §20.1's *\$15.61 per student per year* is the entire argument.
- **When the honest answer is "you don't need this yet", say it.** It costs one small contract and buys a decade. The proprietor tells other proprietors that StromeX talked them *out* of spending money — which is a more powerful referral than any case study.

4.4 Qualification and disqualification

We walk away when: the institution cannot afford the recurring commitment and would be harmed by trying · the timeline is impossible and the customer will not move it · the scope requires a sector we have no domain expert in (Volume I §14.6) · the work is on the Volume I §7.4 declined list · delivery capacity is not available and cannot be created honestly.

Walking away is a recorded, respected outcome. A salesperson who disqualifies well is more valuable than one who signs badly, and compensation is structured so that this is true in their pay as well as in this document.

4.5 Compensation principles

Commission is paid on **delivered and retained** revenue, not on signature. A contract that churns in year one claws back. Commission on services is weighted below commission on recurring software, because Volume I §6.2's portfolio rule requires it. There is no commission accelerator that would make it rational to oversell a customer.

CHAPTER 5 — PROPOSALS, TENDERS & GOVERNMENT PROCUREMENT

5.1 The absolute rules

No bribery. No facilitation payments. No “processing fees”. No bid-rigging. No shell bidders. Ever, in any market, regardless of local norm or of what a competitor is doing. (Volume I §6.6.) Losing a contract for this reason is a correct outcome and is reported as a win in the integrity record.

If an official requests a payment, the engagement is escalated to the Executive immediately, documented, and — if the request stands — we withdraw and say why in writing.

5.2 The bid/no-bid gate

Bid only when: we meet the mandatory criteria without misrepresentation · we have referenceable delivery at comparable scale · capacity is confirmed for the delivery window · the payment terms are survivable (public-sector payment delay is a real and frequently fatal risk to suppliers our size) · the evaluation is transparent enough that a good bid can win.

5.3 The government value argument

The winning number in a public-sector tender is almost never the total. It is the **per-beneficiary cost**. Volume III §20.4's *≈\$1.48 per student per year* for a 400-school state deployment is the argument, and it is true, which is why it can be defended under scrutiny.

The second argument is auditability: a ministry's fear is not cost, it is a scandal. Published pricing, complete audit logs, published incident history and free public verification are precisely the properties that make a procurement officer safe.

CHAPTER 6 — THE CUSTOMER SUCCESS PLAYBOOK

The most under-invested function in most software companies and the one that determines whether the Volume II §9 moat is ever actually built. Net revenue retention is the metric this chapter exists to move, and Chapter 12 explains why our benchmark is harder than most.

6.1 The eleven stages

Stage 1 — Discovery

Owner: Marketing/Product. Goal: they find us without us paying for it. They arrive via a free tool, a verification page, a referral, a search result or a partner. Success: they get value in the first session without talking to anyone.

Stage 2 — Consultation

Owner: Sales. Goal: understand, not pitch. Free discovery consultation (60 min, physical or remote) and free readiness assessment. The assessment is the most valuable thing we do pre-contract and it is deliberately free (Volume III §2.6) because charging for it means fewer institutions do it, and skipping it is the leading cause of failed implementations. Success: they leave with a written honest assessment they could act on even if they never buy from us.

Stage 3 — Proposal

Owner: Sales. Goal: a document they can defend to their board. Per Chapter 4.2. Success: the buyer can explain the proposal to a trustee without us in the room.

Stage 4 — Onboarding

Owner: Delivery. Goal: time-to-first-value, measured in days. A named delivery lead from day one. A kick-off that establishes: what go-live means, what the customer must provide and by when, who their champion is, and what we will measure. The first-value rule: something real must work within 14 days — a live site, a working admissions form, the first batch of verified certificates. An institution that has waited eight weeks to see anything has begun to doubt, and doubt in week eight is far more expensive than scope in week one.

Stage 5 — Migration

Owner: Delivery. Goal: their history arrives intact. The most technically and emotionally fraught stage. Rules: parallel run before switch-off, always · reconciliation reports the customer signs off · nothing is switched off until its replacement is proven · a documented reverse path.

Stage 6 — Training

Owner: Academy. Goal: staff competence, not attendance. In their language, on their devices, with their data. Role-specific, not generic. Recorded for staff who join later. Redeployment training is free where StromeX automation changed someone's role (Volume I §7.1) — this is the single highest-return line in the entire GTM budget, because staff resistance is the largest cause of failed deployments and this converts the most resistant person into the most invested one.

Stage 7 — Go-live

Owner: Delivery. Goal: an uneventful day. Never during an examination window, results period, or admissions deadline. Hypercare for 14 days: elevated support, daily check-in, a named human. A go-live that needed heroics is reviewed as a planning failure (Volume I §13.1.9).

Stage 8 — Adoption

Owner: Customer Success. Goal: usage, not signature. **Adoption is measured, and low adoption is our problem, not the customer's.** Tracked: active users by role, feature usage against what they bought, workflows completed, support ticket themes. A module bought and unused is a renewal we are going to lose in eleven months, and it is visible now. **The unused-module rule:** if a module is unused for 60 days, we intervene — train, reconfigure, or **proactively remove it and stop charging for it.** Charging for something demonstrably unused is exactly the extractive behaviour Volume I §6.1 exists to prevent.

Stage 9 — Support

Owner: Support. Goal: resolution, and pattern detection. Volume III §17. The standing rule: when something we built is broken, the customer speaks to a human free, on every tier including Foundation. Support tickets are read as product intelligence — three institutions asking the same question is a documentation defect; ten is a product defect.

Stage 10 — Renewal & Expansion

Owner: Customer Success. Goal: earned, not extracted. Chapter 7.

Stage 11 — Advocacy

Owner: Marketing. Goal: they recruit for us. Reference calls, case studies, community contribution, speaking, referral. **Compensated honestly** — referral credits, not undisclosed inducements. No customer appears in our marketing without written permission and an accurate description of what we actually did (Volume II §8).

6.2 Health scoring

Every account carries a health score from measured signals, not from the account manager's feelings:

SIGNAL	WEIGHT	WHY
Active users vs. licensed	High	The leading indicator of everything
Modules used vs. purchased	High	Directly predicts non-renewal
Core workflow completion	High	Are they actually running on us?
Support ticket sentiment & recurrence	Medium	Repeated same-theme tickets = unresolved friction
Champion still employed	High	Champion departure is the most under-weighted churn signal in this industry
Payment behaviour	Medium	Late payment often precedes churn, and often signals distress we could help with

SIGNAL	WEIGHT	WHY
Value ledger trend	High	Are we actually delivering measurable gain?
Executive engagement	Medium	Does anyone senior know we exist?

Table 4 — Health scoring

Red health triggers an intervention within 5 business days, owned by a named person, with a written plan. Not an email — a plan.

6.3 The value ledger

Volume I §4.4. Maintained continuously per customer: staff-hours returned, fee collection rate change, admissions cycle time, certificate fraud incidents prevented, print cost avoided, error rates. Shown at every renewal **including the periods where the numbers are unimpressive**. A renewal conversation with no value ledger is a renewal we have not earned, and presenting only the good quarters teaches the customer that our numbers are marketing.

CHAPTER 7 — RETENTION, EXPANSION & THE RENEWAL DOCTRINE

7.1 The honest benchmark problem

Published 2026 B2B SaaS benchmarks put median net revenue retention at roughly **108%**, but segmented by contract value the picture is unforgiving for a business like ours: accounts below ~\$25k ACV show median NRR around **97%**, mid-market around **108%**, and enterprise (>\$100k ACV) around **118%** ([Growthspree](#), [Digital Applied](#)).

Our Phase I customers sit squarely in the sub-\$25k band, where the median company *shrinks* its existing customer base year over year. This is the most important uncomfortable fact in this volume, and the financial model in Volume VIII is built on it rather than around it.

Our target is 105–112% NRR in Phase I, rising toward 115%+ as ACV grows in Phase II. Beating the segment median by 8–15 points is achievable but it is not automatic, and it requires exactly three things:

- 11. A genuine expansion ladder** — the Volume I §6.5 module ladder is the mechanism. Institutions grow into more modules year over year, which is the only reliable source of expansion revenue in a market where we cannot raise prices aggressively.
- 12. Gross retention above 92%** — which in this market means surviving fee-collection stress, proprietor changes and FX shocks. Chapter 7.3.
- 13. Adoption as a managed function, not a hope** — Chapter 6.2.

If we cannot demonstrate NRR above 105% by the end of Phase I, the Volume VIII growth scenarios do not hold and the plan must be revised rather than the number defended.

7.2 The renewal doctrine

- **No auto-renewal without notice.** 60 days' notice, in plain language, stating the amount.
- **No price increase mid-term.** At renewal, capped at 12% annually without documented, communicated scope increase (Volume I §6.3.6).
- **Cancelling is easier than subscribing.** Measured, reported, and a defect if it is not true.
- **Downgrade is self-serve.** “Contact sales to downgrade” is a prohibited pattern.
- **We proactively remove what they don't use** (Chapter 6.1, Stage 8).
- **We tell them when a cheaper configuration would serve them better.** This costs revenue in the quarter and is the single most effective retention action available.

7.3 Churn: causes and countermeasures

CAUSE	FREQUENCY IN OUR MARKET	COUNTERMEASURE
Cannot afford it	High	Downgrade path offered before churn; Band A pricing; instalment terms; honest qualification at Stage 2
Never adopted it	High	Stage 8 adoption management; unused-module removal
Champion left	High	Multi-threading — never fewer than three relationships in any account above Standard
Proprietor/leadership	Medium	Executive re-onboarding within 30

CAUSE	FREQUENCY IN OUR MARKET	COUNTERMEASURE
change		days of any leadership change
Delivery failure	Medium	Volume I §14.2; capacity confirmed before signature
Outgrew us	Low	Should not happen; if it does, it is a product roadmap input, urgently
Competitor	Low-Medium	Usually a symptom of one of the above, not a cause; recorded honestly

Table 5 — Churn: causes and countermeasures

Every churn is logged with a real reason and reviewed monthly. “Price” is not accepted as a reason without evidence (Volume II §5.2.5).

7.4 The win-back rule

An institution that leaves keeps its data export, its verification pages stay live for issued credentials, and it is treated with the same courtesy as a customer. **Credentials already issued remain verifiable forever regardless of whether the institution is still a customer** — because the graduate did nothing wrong, and holding a graduate’s verifiable degree hostage to their school’s subscription would be exactly the data hostage-taking Volume I P5 forbids. This is also, incidentally, the most effective win-back mechanism we have.

CHAPTER 8 — MARKETING

8.1 The mix

CHANNEL	ROLE	PHASE
SEO & content	The primary engine. Compounds. Answers the questions institutions actually search	I onward
Free tools	Distribution disguised as generosity (Volume I §5.3)	I onward
Verification pages	Passive, permanent, high-credibility exposure to employers and universities	I onward
Referral programme	The highest-converting channel in an owner-led market	I onward
Reference deployments	One visible institution recruits its peers	I onward
Community & events	Proprietor associations, education fairs, faith networks	I onward
Partner co-marketing	Their audience, shared cost	II
Developer relations	Ecosystem seeding	II
Press & thought leadership	Credibility with ministries and enterprise	II
Paid acquisition	Only in Band C markets where LTV supports it	III
Annual summit	The ecosystem's centre of gravity	II onward

Table 6 — The mix

8.2 Content strategy

We publish what an institution needs whether or not they buy from us: how to run an admissions cycle, how to write a safeguarding policy, how to prepare for accreditation, how to move records off paper, how certificate verification actually works, what school software should cost. **The honest guide to pricing in our own category is published, including where we are more expensive than a competitor and why.**

This works for a specific reason: our buyers search for problems, not for products. A proprietor searching “how to stop certificate forgery” is worth more than one searching “school management software”, is cheaper to reach, and arrives already trusting us.

8.3 Marketing rules

Every claim substantiated (Volume II §7.4 — five proof points, and no sixth until a sixth is true) · no fabricated testimonials, reviews, case studies or statistics, ever (Volume I §7.2.3) · no fear-selling · no competitor disparagement by name · no pre-announcing unshipped products (Volume II §8) · all pricing in marketing matches Volume III exactly · every customer story approved in writing and accurate about what we actually did.

CHAPTER 9 — THE PARTNER NETWORK

9.1 The strategic logic

The most fragmented part of the competitive landscape — freelancers and small agencies (Volume II §5.1, Class 5) — is simultaneously the largest untapped distribution network in our market. They have the relationships. They lack product, continuity, security posture and scale. **We do not compete with them at the bottom of the market; we recruit them.**

This converts our most numerous competitor into our distribution channel, and it is how the group reaches thousands of institutions without thousands of employees.

9.2 Partner tiers

TIER	WHO	MARGIN / SHARE	REQUIREMENTS
Referral	Anyone	10% of year-1 revenue	Register the deal
Reseller	Agencies, ICT firms	25–35%	1 certified person, 2 deals/yr
Delivery Partner	Implementation firms	30–40% of services	2 certified implementers, quality audit
Solution Partner	Sector specialists	35–45%	Domain expertise, 5 references
White-label Partner	Established brands	65% of end revenue to partner	Volume commitment, quality audit
Distributor	Country/regional	Negotiated	Market commitment, local entity, support capability

Table 7 — Partner tiers

9.3 What we give partners

Certification and training (Volume III Division 15) · deal registration with real protection · demo environments · co-branded and white-label materials · pre-sales support · technical escalation · a partner portal with pipeline, resources and payouts · leads routed by geography and specialism · co-marketing funds at Solution tier and above.

9.4 What we require

Certified staff · adherence to Volume III pricing (partners set their own services margin but do not undercut published software prices, which would destroy the transparency wedge for everyone) · the Volume I §6.6 prohibited-practices standard · customer satisfaction above a threshold · annual recertification · **no misrepresentation of what StromeX does** — a partner overselling capability damages us and is grounds for termination.

9.5 The partner covenant

We will not compete with a partner on their registered deal. We will not take a partner's customer direct. We will not change partner economics without 180 days' notice. If we acquire a company that competes with a partner, we say so immediately and offer a transition.

A partner network that fears the vendor does not invest in the vendor. The economics above are deliberately more generous than the industry norm for the same reason the marketplace rev-share is (Volume III §16.1): a sustainable partner ecosystem is worth more than the extra points.

CHAPTER 10 — THE PLATFORM ECOSYSTEM

10.1 Why we open the platform

A closed platform grows at the rate we can hire. An open one grows at the rate the world can build. The ecosystem exists so that capabilities we would never prioritise — a Kano-specific fee-collection integration, a Ghanaian examination-board connector, an Urdu madrasah module — get built by people closer to the need than we will ever be.

10.2 The ecosystem surfaces

SURFACE	WHAT THIRD PARTIES BUILD	TERMS
REST API	Anything	Free; commercial tier at high volume
Webhooks & events	Reactive integrations	Free
SDKs (JS, Python, PHP)	Client libraries	Free, open source
Design system	Consistent UI on top of us	Free, open source
Plugins	In-product extensions	Marketplace, 20% rev-share
Mini-apps	Embedded experiences inside portals	Marketplace
AI agents	Custom agents for niches	Marketplace
Connectors	Third-party system bridges	Marketplace
Themes & templates	Design assets, document templates	Marketplace
Sector modules	Whole verticals we have not entered	Solution Partner terms
Embedded/OEM	StromeX modules inside another product	Volume III §16.2

Table 8 — The ecosystem surfaces

10.3 The developer promise

Documentation is free and public · the same API we use is the API you get (Volume IV §6, dogfooding rule) · versions are supported 24 months after supersession · breaking changes never happen within a version · rate limits are published and generous · a free sandbox with realistic seed data · **we will not clone your successful extension and bundle it** — if a marketplace extension becomes essential, we acquire it or partner, we do not copy it. This last commitment is what makes the ecosystem investable by anyone other than us, and breaking it once would end the ecosystem permanently.

10.4 Marketplace quality

Every listing is reviewed before publication: does what it claims, handles data per Volume IV §9, does not exfiltrate customer data, states its pricing clearly, has a support contact. Listings that break customer trust are removed and the seller is barred. **We are accountable to the customer for the marketplace even where we did not build the extension** — an institution has one relationship, with us.

CHAPTER 11 — COMMUNITY, ACADEMY & ADVOCACY

11.1 StromeX Academy

Volume III Division 15. Free documentation, video library, community forum and onboarding webinars; paid training and certification where a credential confers real value. Certifications: Certified Administrator, Certified Implementer, Certified Partner Engineer, Certified Designer.

The certification must be worth something in the labour market or it is not worth selling. That means it must be genuinely difficult, independently verifiable (using our own credential infrastructure — we verify our own certificates with the same system we sell), and recognised by employers because certified people are demonstrably better. A certification that everyone passes is a receipt, not a credential.

11.2 Community programmes

PROGRAMME	PURPOSE	PHASE
Community forum	Peer support; reduces support load; surfaces product truth	I
Open-source community	Design system, SDKs, exporters	I
Educator community	Curriculum, templates, question banks shared between institutions	I
Campus ambassadors	Students at universities we serve	II
Student ambassadors	Secondary students; the next generation of developers	II
Developer community	Ecosystem builders	II
User conferences (regional)	Customers meet each other; the strongest retention event there is	II
The annual summit	The ecosystem's centre of gravity; customers, partners, developers, government	II
Research fellows	Volume IX, Chapter 3	II

Table 9 — Community programmes

11.3 The advocacy principle

An advocate is a customer who recruits for us because the product and the relationship earned it. Advocacy cannot be bought, and attempting to buy it (paid testimonials, undisclosed inducements, review incentives) is prohibited and would destroy the only asset — credibility — that makes the referral engine work in the first place.

Referral credits are legitimate, disclosed, and modest. The advocacy itself must be free.

CHAPTER 12 — GTM METRICS

Reviewed monthly by the Executive. Every metric has a named owner.

12.1 Acquisition

Free-tier monthly active institutions · free-to-identified conversion · identified-to-qualified · qualified-to-customer · CAC by motion and by channel · **CAC payback in months** (target <12 for low-touch, <18 for consultative) · organic traffic and ranked keywords · verification-page sessions (the passive engine) · referral share of new customers (target: >35% by end of Phase I) · partner share of new customers (target: >30% by end of Phase II).

12.2 Delivery

Time to first value (target <14 days) · time to go-live vs. committed · implementation margin vs. Volume I §6.2 band · go-lives requiring heroics (target: zero) · migration reconciliation exceptions.

12.3 Retention & expansion

Gross revenue retention (target >92%) · **net revenue retention** (target 105–112% Phase I, >115% Phase II — Chapter 7.1) · logo churn with real reasons · adoption rate per module · unused-module count · health score distribution · red accounts with an active written plan (target: 100%).

12.4 Trust

Cancellation clicks vs. sign-up clicks (must be fewer) · support first-response and resolution times by tier · incidents published within commitment · SLA credits applied automatically · **customer-reported “would recommend”**, collected honestly and reported including the bad quarters.

12.5 The metric we refuse to optimise

Signature volume disconnected from adoption. A quarter of strong bookings and weak adoption is a bad quarter reported as a good one, and it is the precise mechanism by which software companies destroy their own next three years. Bookings are reported alongside 90-day adoption, always, in the same table.

Glossary

Terms are defined as this corpus uses them. Where a term also has a general industry meaning, the definition here governs internally and the cross-reference points to the chapter in which the term is established.

TERM	DEFINITION
ACV	Annual contract value. The recurring revenue a customer contributes in a year, excluding one-time implementation and build fees.
Band A / B / C	The three regional price bands defined in Volume I §6.4. All catalogue prices are quoted at Band C (list); Band A applies a 0.32× multiplier and Band B a 0.65×. The band follows the institution's operating jurisdiction, not its billing address.
CAC	Customer acquisition cost. Loaded sales and marketing cost divided by customers acquired in the period.
CAC payback	The number of months of gross profit from a customer required to recover that customer's acquisition cost.
Craft standard	The requirement in Volume VI §2.1 that creative work be indistinguishable from that of a good London or New York studio while remaining reproducible by a regional printer on the first attempt.
Credential	Any institution-issued, cryptographically signed record of an award, qualification, identity or transaction that a third party may need to verify. The subject of Volume IV, Chapter 5.
Degraded mode	The defined, designed and tested behaviour of a surface under failure — no network, slow network, provider outage. Required of every surface by Volume IV §10.2.
Ecosystem	A complete sector solution spanning all eight architectural layers, rather than a product sold into a sector. The unit of strategic expansion; see Volume I, Chapter 2.
Entrenched provision	A clause amendable only by board supermajority with published rationale and thirty days' notice. Enumerated in Volume IX §9.2.
Federation	Server-to-server interoperation across independently operated instances, allowing an institution to own its data while remaining reachable. The basis of the SpaceTalk government strategy; Volume X, Chapter 5.
Foundation tier	The permanently free tier. Not a trial and not a demo; governed by the Free Constitution in Volume I, Chapter 5.
Gate	A set of conditions that must be met before a roadmap phase may end. A phase ends when its gate is passed, not when its years elapse. Volume VIII, Chapter 2.
GRR	Gross revenue retention. Recurring revenue retained from existing customers excluding expansion; measures churn alone.
Guilloche	Fine mathematical line-work used in security printing, extremely difficult to reproduce by scan-and-print. The primary visual security element of a StromeX credential; Volume VI §6.2.
Human-in-the-loop	The requirement that a named human decides, and is recorded as deciding, wherever the stakes ladder classifies a decision as high. Volume IV §8.1.
LTV	Lifetime value. The discounted gross profit expected from a customer over the expected life of the relationship.

TERM	DEFINITION
No-fork rule	The prohibition on forking shared platform layers for a single customer without written CTO approval and a sunset date. Volume IV §3.2.
NRR	Net revenue retention. Recurring revenue from existing customers including expansion and contraction. Above 100% means the existing base grows without new customers.
Pricing Council	The standing body that owns Volume III, meets quarterly, and reviews every price against delivered margin. Volume I §8.4.
Reference Implementation	A delivered institutional deployment used as proof of method and as a permanent sales asset. Four are recorded in this edition.
Rule of 40	Revenue growth percentage plus operating margin percentage. A common composite measure of whether a software company balances growth against profitability.
Stakes ladder	The four-level classification — low, medium, high, prohibited — determining how much autonomy an AI system may exercise over a decision. Volume IV §8.1.
System of record	The authoritative store of an institution's people, money, documents, credentials and decisions. Identified in Volume II §9 as the group's only genuinely durable moat.
Value ledger	The running, honest account of what an institution has gained from StromeX, shown at every renewal including the periods where the numbers are unimpressive. Volume I §4.4.
Verification token	A prepaid unit purchased by an institution for verification-adjacent services carrying real marginal cost. Verification itself is always free to the verifier. Volume III §3.5.
Wave	A group of industry ecosystems opened in the same roadmap phase. Volume I §2.2.

Table 10 — Glossary of terms

References & Bibliography

Every external figure in this corpus is attributed at the point of use. This list consolidates those sources and records what each was used for. Sources were consulted in August 2026; where a source reports a market figure that moves, the figure is dated in the text.

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Internal sources

Claims in this corpus about what the group has built trace to these. Catalogue lines in Volume III are marked built, partial or specified-not-built on this basis.

StromeX MVP · [apps/api](#), [apps/web](#), [infra](#)

FastAPI backend with multi-provider AI routing, memory, spaced-repetition tutor and PDF export; Next.js frontend; Docker Compose infrastructure. Establishes the canonical stack in Volume IV §2.2.

Independent MVP Audit · [docs/04-STROMEX-INDEPENDENT-AUDIT.md](#)

Security, scalability, reliability and performance audit including a critical server-side request forgery vulnerability found, reproduced and fixed. Carried forward as a standing engineering rule in Volume IV §15.

Reference Implementation №1 · [Sultan Hanafi Royal Schools](#)

Four-language institutional build (English, Arabic RTL, Yorùbá, French) with approximately thirty-five page templates per locale; four verification surfaces; certificate generation with documented identifier architecture, security model and signing-key deployment; digital identity and card system; finance platform; eight role portals; personalisation centre; and approximately one hundred and twenty institutional system, governance and design documents.

Reference Implementation №2 · [WorldWide English College](#)

A seventy-three-table credential and commerce schema across fifteen migrations, covering enrolment integrity, competencies, evidence, awards, credential signing, issued documents, verifying institutions, payments, instalment plans, multi-currency routing, corporate seats and alumni chapters. The evidential basis for Volume IV §4.2.

Reference Implementation №3 · [Al-Madeenah College](#)

Bilingual static build system with offline service worker, verification surfaces, font subsetting pipeline and document generation to PDF and DOCX.

Reference Implementation №4 · [Institutional portal system](#)

Multi-role portal implementation covering student, staff, parent, applicant and administrative roles, admissions pipeline, attendance, timetable, assessment, finance and library.

Index

Generated by the build. Page references point to where each concept is established or substantively discussed; passing mentions are not indexed. Word index markers are also embedded throughout the corpus, so a live index can be built in Word if preferred.

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Colophon

This edition is composed for A4 at 210 × 297 mm. Display matter is set in a serif book face and running text in a companion serif, with a sans for tables, captions and navigation and a monospaced face for code and architecture figures — the four typographic roles defined in Volume I, Chapter 10. The StromeX brand faces, **Archivo** and **Fraunces**, ship with this edition in [docs/bible/publication/fonts/](#); the build selects them automatically wherever they are installed in the rendering environment, so the corpus can be reissued in full brand typography without editing a line of it.

The rules, tables and figures follow the design laws in Volume I, Chapter 12: typography carries the interface, space is a component, colour carries meaning, and structural devices encode something true about the content rather than decorating it. Tables use horizontal rules only; the vertical grid is carried by alignment, as it is in every well-set financial document.

This DOCX is the authoritative master. The press-quality PDF edition is generated from it and is content-identical. Both are produced from the markdown corpus of record under version control at [docs/bible/](#), by the build recorded at [docs/bible/publication/](#), so that the publication can be regenerated exactly whenever the corpus is amended.

THE STROME X EDITORIAL BIBLE · Edition II ·
VERSION 2.0

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